The Agnipath Scheme

When I had first sounded out the PM about the Tour of Duty scheme, it was more on the lines of a short-service option at the soldier level, similar to the Short Service Commission scheme for officers that was already in vogue. Just as a limited number of SSC officers are taken each year, likewise a limited number of jawans would be similarly enrolled and released after the completion of their 'tour' with the option of re-enlisting for another tour, if found to be fit. The terms and conditions of service in terms of pay and allowances would be the same for everyone, as in the case of SSC officers with respect to their Permanently Commissioned counterparts. Since the SSC Officers scheme already existed, it would require only a little bit of tweaking to be introduced as a Short Service Enrolment scheme for other ranks, purely for the Army.

Nothing much happened in the next couple of months as the onset of the Covid pandemic grabbed all our attention, followed by the clashes in Galwan. However, the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) was considering this proposal but with a much wider scope and applicability. In the PMO formulation, not only should the complete intake of the year be short-service based, but it would also apply to all three Services. Having become a tri-service matter, it now fell on the CDS, Gen Bipin Rawat, to take the proposal forward, albeit with the Army remaining the lead service. We in the Army were taken by surprise by this turn of events, but for the Navy and Air Force, it came like a bolt from the blue. It took me some time to explain to the other Chiefs that my proposal had only been Army-centric and that I was equally surprised by these developments, and it took them some time to reconcile with the fact that they were very much part of the new proposal, dubbed the 'Agnipath' (Walk

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